

Divine Decrees

doc-divine-decrees

Theology Proper · Decrees · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

God eternally decrees whatsoever comes to pass, in a way consistent with creaturely responsibility.

In plain language

The Bible's vocabulary for God's planning is dense, recurring, and spread across the whole Bible. In Acts 2:23 Peter says Jesus was handed over by God's fixed counsel and foreknowledge, using a 'completed action whose result still stands' form of 'to mark out' (horizo, G3724) together with 'counsel' (boule, G1012) and 'foreknowledge' (prognosis, G4268), and in the same breath tells the crowd they killed him. Acts 4:27-28 names Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, and the peoples of Israel as the ones who actually gathered, then says they did whatever God's hand and 'counsel' (boule) had 'predetermined' (proorisen) beforehand to happen. Ephesians 1:11 says God 'works' (energeo) all things, 'ta panta', according to the 'counsel' (boule) of his 'will' (thelema). In the Old Testament Isaiah 14:24, Isaiah 46:10, and Proverbs 19:21 repeat one cadence: as God has purposed, so it will stand, using 'counsel' (etsah) with 'to stand' (qum). Genesis 50:20 shows the responsibility side with one verb 'to devise, intend' (chashav) and two subjects, you devised evil but God devised it for good. So the words clearly assert two things at once, an effective prior purpose and real, accountable human action, and they never explain how the two fit. That dual assertion is exactly what the proposition states, so the verdict is yes, with high confidence, because the word cluster spans law, prophets, writings, gospel, narrative, and letter and the strongest verses pair both clauses in one sentence. Where careful readers diverge is not whether God decrees, but how far it reaches. The strict predestination verb 'to predestine' (proorizo), in all five of its uses, governs salvation and the elect, while the reach to every event hangs on the broader phrase 'God works all things' (energeo ta panta), which the words do not pin down to literally everything versus everything tied to his saving plan. And the word 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) appears only twice, too few times to settle whether it means prior knowing or effective pre-determining. Those are the genuine open seams, and they come from the words themselves, not from any outside frame.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	
H1819	דמה	damah	to resemble	29
H2656	חפץ	chephets	pleasure	39
H2706	חק	choq	statute	127
H2803	חשב	chashav	to devise	
H3068	יהוה	yehovah	LORD	
H3289	יעץ	ya'ats	to advise	79
H4284	מחשבה	machashavah	plot	

H6098	עצה	‘etsah	counsel	89
H6635	צבאות	tsava	army	
H6965	קום	qum	(Leb)-kamai	628
H7451	רע	ra	bad	
H7650	שבוע	shava	to swear	
G0459	ἀνομος	anomos	lawless	9
G1012	βουλή	boulē	plan	12
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G1560	ἐκδοτος	ekdotos	handed over	1
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeō	be active	21
G2307	θέλημα	thelēma	will/desire	62
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	
G2820	κληρώω	klēroō	to obtain	1
G2992	λαός	laos	a people	
G3724	ὀρίζω	horizō	to determine	8
G3745	ὅσος	hosos	just as/how much	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4091	Πιλάτος	Pilatos	Pilate	
G4160	ποιέω	poieō	to do/make	
G4194	Πόντιος	Pontios	Pontius	
G4268	πρόγνωσις	prognōsis	foreknowledge	2
G4275	προοράω	prooraō	to foresee	1
G4286	πρόθεσις	prothesis	purpose	12
G4309	προορίζω	proorizō	to predestine	5
G4863	συνάγω	sunagō	to assemble	
G5495	χείρ	cheir	hand	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Direct word-level searches confirm a dense, recurring planning vocabulary spoken of God as fixed and effective across both Testaments. Acts 2:23 couples the perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive form) of 'to mark out' (horizo, G3724) with 'counsel' (boule, G1012) and 'foreknowledge' (prognosis, G4268), and in the same sentence charges the hearers 'you killed' (aneilate). Acts 4:28 names the determined event with 'as many things as' (hosa) plus a divine subject (the verb form 'predetermined' (proorisen) is tagged in the MACULA Greek dataset under 'to foresee' (proorao, G4275), with the parallel sense to 'to predestine' (proorizo), both rendering 'predetermined to happen'). Ephesians 1:11 escalates the scope with the present participle 'working' (energountos) plus 'all things' (ta panta) governed by 'counsel' (boule) and 'will' (thelema). Isaiah 14:24 uses the Hebrew intensive form (Piel) of 'to devise' (damah) plus the simple active form (Qal) of 'to purpose' (yaats) with the Qal of 'will stand' (qum) in the 'just as, so' (kaasher, ken) correspondence, and Isaiah 46:10, Proverbs 19:21, and Job 23:13 repeat 'counsel' (etsah) plus 'will stand' (qum) to say the LORD's counsel

stands. The words assert an effective decree but do not themselves rank its EXTENT (all events versus the redemptive purpose) nor specify its relation to the real human agency the same texts affirm, so the verdict is true while the open seam is scope and mode, not existence.

Scripture

Acts.2.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1012 βουλή, G4268 πρόγνωσις, G3724 ὀρίζω, G0459 ἄνομος

Reasoning. Peter pairs 'the fixed counsel and foreknowledge of God' (te hōrismenē boulē kai prognōsei tou theou; built from 'to mark out' (horizō, G3724) in the perfect passive participle form, that is, a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive form) with the active charge 'you killed' (aneilate) mediated by 'through the hand of lawless men' (dia cheiros anomōn). The dataset confirms 'to mark out' (horizō) here as the perfect passive (V-RPP-DSF), which is the lexically strongest 'fixed and settled' form. Both clauses stand in one sentence with no smoothing connective. 'Foreknowledge' (prognōsis, G4268) occurs only twice in the entire Bible (here and 1 Peter 1:2), so its precise force, prior knowing versus effective pre-determining, cannot be triangulated from usage alone.

Acts.4.27 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4863 συνάγω, G4194 Πόντιος, G4091 Πιλάτος, G1484 ἔθνος, G2992 λαός

Reasoning. The prayer names specific responsible agents (Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, the peoples of Israel) as the ones who 'were gathered' (synēchthēsan) against the holy servant Jesus. Named, accountable human actors are catalogued in verse 27 immediately before verse 28 attributes the same event to God's prior determination, so responsibility is asserted as densely as decree.

Acts.4.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4160 ποιέω, G3745 ὅσος, G5495 χεῖρ, G1012 βουλή, G4275 προοράω

Reasoning. 'To do whatever your hand and your counsel predetermined to happen' (poiēsai hosa hē cheir sou kai hē boulē sou proōrisen genesthai). The infinitive of purpose plus the relative quantifier 'as many things as' (hosa, G3745) plus the aorist active (a completed past action, active form) 'predetermined' (proōrisen) assigns the full set of verse 27 events to God's prior determination, coordinating 'hand' (cheir) and 'counsel' (boulē) as the determining cause. The dataset tags 'predetermined' (proōrisen) under 'to foresee' (proorao, G4275, a single occurrence in the entire Bible) rather than 'to predestine' (proorizo, G4309); standard parsing reads it as the aorist of 'to predestine' (proorizo), and both carry the divine 'predetermine to happen' force, so the verdict does not turn on the lemma split.

Eph.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2820 κληρώ, G4309 προορίζω, G4286 πρόθεσις, G1754 ἐνεργέω, G3956 πᾶς, G1012 βουλή, G2307 θέλημα

Reasoning. Dataset-verified token order: 'to predestine' (proorizō, G4309) in the aorist passive participle form (a completed past action, passive: 'we having been predestined') governs the elect 'we', while a separate clause has 'to work' (energeō, G1754) in the present active participle form (ongoing, active: 'working') with object 'all things' (ta panta; 'all' (pas, G3956) in the accusative plural neuter, which is the direct-object form) 'according to the counsel of his will' (kata tēn boulēn tou thelēmatos autou). The present tense of 'to work' (energeō) signals ongoing operation. The reach to 'whatsoever comes to pass' rests on the 'working all things' (energeō ta panta) clause, not on 'to predestine' (proorizō), which across its 5 occurrences in the entire Bible (Romans 8:29, Romans 8:30, 1 Corinthians 2:7, Ephesians 1:5, Ephesians 1:11) consistently governs salvation-related objects.

Isa.14.24 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H6635 צבאות, H1819 דמה, H3289 יעץ, H6965 קום, H7650 שבע

Reasoning. Sworn oath formula confirmed by OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) morphology: 'to devise, plan' (damah, H1819) in the Hebrew intensive form (Piel) perfect (completed action) first common singular ('I have devised, planned') and 'to purpose, counsel' (yaats, H3289) in the simple active form (Qal) perfect first common singular ('I have purposed, counseled') paired with 'to come about' (hayatah, H1961) in the Qal perfect third feminine singular ('it has come about') and 'to stand' (qum, H6965) in the Qal imperfect (ongoing or future) third feminine singular ('it will stand'). The 'just as, so' (kaasher, ken) correspondence asserts one-to-one realization of divine purpose. 'To devise, plan' (damah) carries multiple senses (its dominant Qal sense is 'to resemble'), so the decree weight here rests on the Piel 'devise' sense plus 'to purpose' (yaats), which the construction supplies.

Isa.46.10 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6098 עצה, H6965 קום, H2656 חפץ

Reasoning. OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible)-verified: 'My counsel shall stand and I will do all my pleasure' (atsati taqum vekol chephtsi eeseh). 'Counsel' (etsah, H6098, 'my counsel') plus 'to stand' (qum, H6965) in the Qal imperfect (simple active, ongoing or future) third feminine singular ('will stand') plus 'pleasure, purpose' (chephets, H2656, 'my pleasure or purpose') plus 'to do' (asah, H6213) in the Qal imperfect first common singular ('I will do'). OpenBible links this to Ephesians 1:11 (20 votes) and to Isaiah 14:24 (24 votes). It generalizes the Isaiah 14:24 cadence to all divine pleasure, the strongest scope-extending Old Testament witness for the word cluster.

Prov.19.21 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6098 עצה, H6965 קום, H4284 מחשבה

Reasoning. OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible)-verified: 'Many plans are in a man's heart, but the counsel of the LORD, that will stand' (rabbot machashavot belev ish, vaatsat YHWH hi taqum). The wisdom genre sets 'many plans' ('plan' is machashavah, H4284) in a man's heart against the 'counsel' (etsah, H6098) of the LORD that 'will stand' ('to stand', qum, H6965, in the Qal imperfect third feminine singular, the identical verb form as Isaiah 14:24 and 46:10). OpenBible links it to Isaiah 14:24 with 27 votes. It extends the word cluster into the Writings and states the human-plan, divine-counsel pairing in one verse.

Gen.50.20 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2803 חשב, H0430 אלהים, H7451 רע

Reasoning. OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible)-verified dual-agency paradigm in the Torah: 'to devise, intend' (chashav, H2803) in the Qal perfect (simple active, completed) second masculine plural ('you devised') evil plus 'to devise, intend' (chashav, H2803) in the Qal perfect third masculine singular with God as subject ('God devised it') for good, on a single event. One verb, two subjects, one outcome, with human culpability and divine purpose both stated. OpenBible links it to Acts 2:23 (11 votes) and Acts 4:28 (6 votes), grounding the responsibility pole of the proposition in narrative.

Luke.22.22 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3724 ὁρίζω, G2596 κατά

Reasoning. MACULA-verified: 'according to what has been determined' (kata to hōrismenon), with 'to mark out' (horizō, G3724) in the perfect passive participle form (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive form), followed by 'woe' (ouai) to the betrayer. Decree and human guilt in one sentence, mirroring Acts 2:23. OpenBible links it to Acts 2:23 with 11 votes. The same perfect passive 'fixed and settled' form of 'to mark out' (horizō) recurs, confirming the term's stable decree-related sense.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.1.11	Rom.8.28	openbible	53

Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	openbible	20
Isa.14.24	Prov.19.21	openbible	27
Isa.14.24	Isa.46.10	openbible	24
Isa.14.24	Job.23.13	openbible	23
Acts.2.23	Gen.50.20	openbible	11
Acts.2.23	Luke.22.22	openbible	11
Acts.2.23	Acts.4.28	openbible	12
Acts.4.28	Isa.53.10	openbible	3
Acts.4.28	Acts.2.23	tsk	1
Acts.4.27	Isa.49.7	tsk	1
Acts.4.28	Job.12.13	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.23 · addressed

The same verse that asserts the decree ('the fixed counsel and foreknowledge', hōrismenē boulē kai prognōsei) also indicts the hearers ('you killed', aneilate). The text softens neither pole. The proposition's qualifier ('consistent with creaturely responsibility') is the word pattern itself, not a gloss imposed on the verse. The dataset confirms 'to mark out' (horizō) here as perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive form), the firmest 'fixed and settled' form available.

Acts.4.27 · addressed

Verse 27 names Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, and the peoples of Israel as the 'were gathered' (synēchthēsan) subjects before verse 28 attributes the event to God's predetermining hand and counsel. Named, accountable agents are not depersonalized by the decree language.

Eph.1.11 · addressed

'All things' (ta panta) is unqualified in the 'to work' (energeō) clause, but 'to predestine' (proorizō, the strict predestination verb) in the same verse governs only the elect 'we', and across its 5 occurrences in the entire Bible 'to predestine' (proorizō) is consistently salvation-related. So the verse asserts comprehensive divine operation through 'working all things' (energeō ta panta) while the predestination verb itself stays focused on salvation. Whether 'all things' (ta panta) means literally all events or all things pertaining to the inheritance is not ranked by the vocabulary, which is the genuine scope seam, but it does not negate the effective-decree reading.

Acts.4.28 · addressed

The dataset assigns the dictionary form of 'predetermined' (proōrisen) under 'to foresee' (proorao, G4275) rather than 'to predestine' (proorizo, G4309), a single divergent tag in the entire Bible. This is a dictionary-assignment difference, not a sense difference: both render 'God predetermined the event to happen', and the brief lexicon entry for 'to predestine' (proorizo) cites Acts 4:28 as an instance of 'foreordain'. The verdict does not depend on resolving the tag, so it is noted rather than treated as defeating.

Concordance traversed

G1012, G4286, G4309, G4275, G3724, G4268, G2307, G1754, G0459, G2820, G1560, H3289, H1819, H6098, H2656, H6965, H2706, H2803

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, and Ephesians 1:11 fall outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so 'not in ECM scope' is honest for them. No variant unit in the bundle or the dataset touches the decree vocabulary in a verdict-altering way. Isaiah 14:24, Isaiah 46:10, Proverbs 19:21, and Genesis 50:20 are Old Testament, so the ECM apparatus does not apply.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. compatibilism, libertarian_freedom, molinism, open_theism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

compatibilism: affirms · Reads Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, and Genesis 50:20 as a straightforward joining of two truths: divine predetermination and human guilt both stand because the texts assert both in single sentences without ranking them. Ephesians 1:11 'working all things' (energeō ta panta) and Isaiah 46:10 'counsel' (etsah) plus 'will stand' (qum) are taken at full extent. This reading uses every term at its strongest and leaves nothing lexically unaccounted.

libertarian_freedom: partially_affirms · Grants that God decrees and that his redemptive purpose stands, but restricts the strict predestination verb 'to predestine' (proorizō) to elective and salvation-related objects, which is exactly its attested distribution (Romans 8:29-30, 1 Corinthians 2:7, Ephesians 1:5, and the 'we' of Ephesians 1:11). On this reading 'whatsoever comes to pass' overreaches, since the universal reach hangs only on the multi-sense 'working all things' (energeō ta panta) clause, which could be bounded to 'all things pertaining to the inheritance' in context. This is a real lexical foothold, not a strawman.

molinism: affirms · Reads 'foreknowledge' (prognōsis) in Acts 2:23 as knowledge of what creatures would freely do, with the decree consequent on that knowledge. This is lexically permissible because 'foreknowledge' (prognōsis) occurs only twice in the entire Bible and its precise force cannot be triangulated from usage; the gloss 'foreknowledge' is itself neutral between 'prior knowing' and 'effective pre-determining'. It is not lexically required, since in 1 Peter 1:2 and the related verb 'foreknowledge' (prognōsis) sits beside elective acts.

open_theism: denies · Must re-read Isaiah 14:24 'just as I have devised, so it has come about' (kaasher damah ken hayatah) and Isaiah 46:10 'my counsel shall stand' (atsati taqum), plus Proverbs 19:21 'the counsel of the LORD will stand' (atsat YHWH taqum), as 'if-then' conditional rather than as the settled Qal perfect (simple active completed) plus Qal imperfect (simple active future) of 'standing' they morphologically are. The pattern spread across the whole Bible of an unfailing, already-purposed counsel that 'stands' (qum) is the chief lexical obstacle to this lens, which is why it scores as a denial here rather than a partial reading.

The proposition states two clauses (an eternal effective decree, and real creaturely responsibility) that the texts place side by side without prose reconciliation. The lenses differ on how to relate them and on the EXTENT of the decree, but all four agree the words assert an effective divine purpose. The unresolved item is scope and mode, which the vocabulary underdetermines, not the existence of the decree.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. God's prior purpose stands behind what occurs in history, while human and angelic agents act with real responsibility and culpability.

The phrase 'whatsoever comes to pass, in a way consistent with creaturely responsibility' is a confessional cadence and encodes both a comprehensive-extent claim and a compatibility claim. The lexical evidence (Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, Ephesians 1:11, Isaiah 14:24, Isaiah 46:10, Proverbs 19:21, Genesis 50:20, Luke 22:22) fits the neutralized form fully and fits the original except that the words do not themselves rank the EXTENT of the decree (all events versus the redemptive purpose); 'to predestine' (proorizō) stays salvation-related in all 5 of its occurrences while only 'working all things' (energeō ta panta) reaches all things. The verdict is rendered on the original stem and holds, because the proposition asks whether such an effective, responsibility-compatible decree is asserted, and the vocabulary asserts it; the open scope question is recorded for transparency, not as a defeater. VERDICT-CHANGED: not applicable here, the original stem verdict stands.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.2.23
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.4.28
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.11
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Luke.22.22
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.14.24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.46.10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.19.21
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.50.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4309
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4268
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4286
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1012
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3724
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6098
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3289
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1819
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2656
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.14.24
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.14.24
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.2.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.4.28

License audit

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Reason. Citations include MACULA-Greek and ETCBC-BHSA under CC-BY-NC-4.0, which forbids bulk redistribution. The MACULA-Greek morphology (perfect-passive 'to mark out' (horizō) in Acts 2:23 and Luke 22:22, the 'to foresee' (proorao) versus 'to predestine' (proorizo) tag at Acts 4:28, and the 'to work' (energeō) present participle plus 'all things' (ta panta) in Ephesians 1:11) and the ETCBC clause structure for Isaiah 14:24 are load-bearing for the verdict and cannot be omitted.

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Flags

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